

The Inference Files: Mystery Case

Teacher: Ms. Williamson • Standards: 6.RC.1–6.RC.3 (textual evidence, inference, and theme)

Where to find it	Canvas → Modules → <i>Absent Teacher Plans 9/28</i> → "9/28 - Inference Escape Room"
What students do	Solve 5 evidence files (18 challenges) in a digital mystery case, then crack the final code.
What they turn in	"The Inference Files - Exit Ticket" on Canvas (same module, 10 points).
Timing	About 25–30 minutes for the mystery case + 10–15 minutes for the exit ticket.
Materials	Student devices with Canvas. Nothing to print.

LESSON PLAN

Time	What to do
0–5 min	Take attendance. Students get devices out and log in to Canvas.
5–10 min	Write on the board: Text clues + What I already know = Inference. Then read aloud: <i>"Today you are an agent at the Inference Bureau. Authors often show instead of tell. They won't say a character is nervous; they describe her tapping her pencil and checking the clock. Your job is to read the clues and figure out what the author means. Solve all 5 evidence files to crack the final code."</i>
10–40 min	Students open the mystery case, choose a level (Explorer, Agent, or Legend), type their name, and work on their own. Walk around and help using the tips below.
40–55 min	Students complete The Inference Files - Exit Ticket and submit it on Canvas.
Early finishers	Replay the mystery case at a harder level (Agent → Legend), or read independently.

EXPECTATIONS FOR STUDENTS

- Work on your own and use quiet voices.
- Stay on the mystery case or exit ticket tab only.
- If you're stuck, reread the evidence, tap **Show a hint**, or use **Supports** before raising your hand.
- Submit the exit ticket on Canvas before the end of class.

IF STUDENTS GET STUCK

- **Ask them:** "What does the text SAY? What do you already KNOW? So what can you figure out?"
- **Hints:** students can tap **Show a hint**. Explorer level also has "remove 2" power-ups.
- **Supports:** read-aloud, bigger text, a word bank, and a scratch pad.
- **Page won't load or looks frozen:** refresh the page. Progress is saved on that device.
- **Please do not use** "Teacher: make a QR code" or "Teacher: reset this device." Reset erases a student's progress.

ANSWER KEY (FOR THE SUBSTITUTE)

Evidence file	Answers
#1 The Tryout	Jada is nervous or anxious. Best evidence: "Jada's stomach dropped to her sneakers. She couldn't make her feet move." The "list" is the list of students who made the team.
#2 The Empty Chair	Grandpa has passed away or is gone. Strong clues: the empty recliner, Mom standing a long time, Mom pressing the paper to her chest without a word. Not strong: the recliner is green; Grandpa used a pen.
#3 The New Kid	Ava is new and lonely or shy. Leo is finding a kind way to share. Theme: small acts of kindness can make a big difference.
#4 The Garden	The street expected Mrs. Kowalski to be upset. She is forgiving and turns a problem into an opportunity. The twins spent the summer learning from her.
#5 Explicit or Inferred?	Explicit: the list goes up at 4:00; Grandpa did the crossword in pen; Leo slid his pretzels to the middle. Inferred: Jada is nervous; Mom is grieving; Leo is trying to welcome Ava. Best sentence starter: "The text states..."
Final code	INFER

NOTES FOR MS. WILLIAMSON

Absent students:

Students who were a great help:

Behavior or tech issues:

Other notes:

Thank you for being here today!